major ones have amenities, including toilets, changing rooms, police posts and tourist centres. A pedestrian walkway also winds down from Godowlia Chowk to Dashashwamedh Ghat.

The Namo Namah ghat, which skirts the Ganga's banks for half a kilometre, has been transformed under the Smart City Mission. Spread across 21,000 sq. metres, its most striking feature is the 25 ft-tall hand sculptures. It also boasts an open air theatre, food court, children's park, free wi-fi and 'India's first floating CNG filling station'. An immersion pool, water sports area and helipad are next on the agenda.

Prof. G.C. Tripathi, former vice-chancellor of BHU, divides the redevelopment of Varanasi into two phases. "The first was between 2014 and 2017 with the Modi government at the Centre and the Samajwadi Party (SP) in power in Uttar Pradesh. The second phase began in 2017, when the Yogi Adityanath government took charge and development plans picked up pace," he says.

Like the Deepotsav held on Chhoti Deepavali in Ayodhya, Yogi started the tradition of holding a grand Dev Deepavali on Varanasi's ghats on the night of Kartik Purnima. Modi himself participated in the Dev Deepavali of November 2020, the highlight of which was the lighting of 1.5 million *diyas* (oil lamps) on the ghats, even though it was in the middle of the Covid-19 crisis. "The Dev Deepavali celebrations attracted a new category of tourists and, with the Kashi Vishwanath Dham, Varanasi's potential as a tourist destination exploded," Tripathi adds.

Religious tourism has really kicked off in Varanasi. This year, a record 16.3 million devotees visited Kashi Vishwanath Dham in the month of *saavan*, which ended on August 31, the first time it has crossed the 10 million figure. Sunil Verma, CEO of the Kashi Vishwanath Temple Trust, says, "Since the inauguration of the Kashi Vishwanath Dham in December 2021, close to 100 million devotees have visited the place." Among the new facilities coming up for the comfort of the devotees is a hangar to protect them from the heat and golf carts to ferry them around. The Manikarnika and Harishchandra ghats, located next to the Kashi Vishwanath Dham, are also getting a Rs 15 crore facelift under the Namami Gange project. As D. Vasudevan, the chief general manager of the Smart City Mission in Varanasi, explains, "Eight new ghats will enhance the crescent-shaped pattern of the Uttar Vahini Ganga." The holy city has 93 ghats now, including Namo Ghat and eight other new ones.

Another thing Varanasi has going for it is Kaush-

A FEW BIG PLANS

₹5,000 cr.
for the ring road around Varanasi. Has 18 projects including roads, railway overbridges, bridges and elevated highways

₹1,171 cr.
for the Madan Mohan Malviya Cancer Centre; Rs 183 cr. for a 430-bed superspeciality hospital at Banaras Hindu University (BHU)

₹712 cr.
for a cricket stadium in Ganjari area and the Dr Sampurnanand Sports Stadium in Sigra

₹416 cr.
for a multi-modal water transport terminal on the banks of the Ganges in Varanasi

₹305 cr.
for the Deen Dayal Hastkala Sankul, a trade centre built by the ministry of textiles

₹308 cr.
for the construction of a 55 MLD sewage treatment plant at Bhagwanpur under Namami Gange

₹172 cr.
for Varanasi police's city command and control centre; 4,500 CCTV cameras installed

₹93 cr.
for International Rice Research Centre, established in collaboration with the Philippines





THE NAMO NAMAH GHAT, WHICH SKIRTS THE GANGA'S BANKS FOR HALF A KILOMETRE AND IS SPREAD ACROSS 21,000 SQ. METRE, HAS BEEN TRANSFORMED UNDER THE SMART CITY MISSION